

STUDY GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS OFFICE ON DRUGS AND CRIME



Agenda 01: Deliberating on Measures to Address Migrant Smuggling and Forced Labour

Agenda 02: Combating Transnational Organised Fraud and Digital Exploitation





Letter from R&D

Dear Delegates,

It gives the Department of Research & Development, MUN Society MPSTME, immense pleasure to welcome you to the 12th edition of Mumbai MUN! True to our legacy, we remain committed to upholding and building upon a tradition of fostering informed discussions on matters of widespread concern.

We are primarily responsible for formulating relevant agendas and developing study guides that aim at imparting a holistic understanding of the issues at hand. This document has been prepared with a *first principles* approach, meant to play a part in orienting the committee discussions towards one that rises above the convention, and is characterised by substantiveness and inclusivity.

This year's theme, 'Voice Amidst the Void,' stands to remind us that when ideals fade into absence, voices must prevail. In an increasingly complex world, with an absence of conviction and shared purpose, we believe that the introduction of new ideas and impactful discourse is the need of the hour. True progress requires us to have the courage and willingness to speak up, have our perspectives heard, and to make sure that no voice is lost amidst a void of apathy.

Keeping this theme in mind, we have deliberately curated committees and agendas that focus on issues often overlooked in global conversations, in order to foster meaningful dialogue and resolution where it is most needed. In this study guide, you will find well-researched background information to help you prepare for your committee sessions. As facilitators, our aim is to equip you with the resources and insights you need to make the most out of your experience at Mumbai MUN.

We look forward to your active participation and contributions during Mumbai MUN and are confident that, together, we can make this conference an inspiring, enriching, and especially memorable experience for all.

Best wishes,

Department of Research & Development,
MUNSociety MPSTME.

Contents

Agenda 1: Deliberating on Measures to Address Migrant Smuggling and Forced Labour	1
COMMITTEE OVERVIEW	1
AGENDA OVERVIEW	1
BACKGROUND	2
ROOTS AND CAUSES	2
Scarcity of Formal Support Structures	2
Commercial Interest	2
Poverty and Income Inequality	3
MIGRATION	3
Smuggling Routes	3
Border Control	4
LABOUR	4
Bondage and Slave Labour	4
Unethical Recruitment	4
Kafala System	4
Workers' Rights	5
CHALLENGES	5
Sexual and Gendered Violence	5
Organised Criminal Networks and Their Influence	5
Lack of Labour Standards	6
Victim Identification	6
Maritime Smuggling	6
INITIATIVES AND COLLABORATIONS	7
GOALS Programme with IMO, ILO, and UNW	7
Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration	7
Palermo Protocol	8
CASE STUDIES	8
USA-Mexico Border Crisis	8
Rohingya Crisis, Myanmar	9
2022 Qatar FIFA World Cup	10
MAJOR ACTORS	10
Cambodia	10
Libya	11
United Arab Emirates	11
IMPACTS	11
Exploitation of Cheap, Illegal labour	11
Corruption and Destabilisation of the Government	12
Humanitarian Crisis with Poor Worker Conditions	12
CONCLUSION	13
Agenda 2: Combating Transnational Organised Fraud and Digital Exploitation	14
AGENDA OVERVIEW	14



BACKGROUND	14
CYBERCRIME	15
Digital Marketplaces	15
Phishing, Trojans	15
Pig-Butchering	15
Illicit Surveillance	15
CHALLENGES	15
Jurisdictional Complexity	15
Arms Race between Law Enforcement and Criminals	16
Lack of Public Awareness	16
Encryption and Codes	16
IMPACTS	17
Large-scale Fiscal Losses	17
Psychological Fallout	17
Damage to Financial Institutions	17
Creation of Anonymity-driven Safe Havens for Crime and Illegal trade	17
INITIATIVES	18
UNGA Adoption of the Cybercrime Convention	18
INTERPOL Collaborations	18
Emergency Response Network (ERN)	18
FRONTEX Collaboration	18
NATIONAL STANCES	19
United States of America	19
Iran	19
Brazil	20
CASE STUDIES	20
Large-Scale Scam Compounds in South East Asia	20
Bankruptcy of FTX in The Bahamas	20
Romance Investment Scams in Australia	21
CONCLUSION	21

Agenda 1: Deliberating on Measures to Address Migrant Smuggling and Forced Labour

COMMITTEE OVERVIEW

Started in 1997, the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) is the UN-specific body that works to curb drugs, crime, terrorism, and corruption. It is an executive body that plays a vital role in establishing its criminal justice and security mandates within the UN system as a whole, and in assisting member states in translating their commitments into action.¹

UNODC's comparative advantage is its expertise in the broad area of criminal justice system reform, in which it helps to understand organised crime, combating the global drug networks, and collaborating on other problem areas such as corruption, research, and terrorism prevention. UNODC works with many stakeholders to maximise the impact of their work. These include governments, civil society organisations, academic and research institutions, the private sector, international and regional organisations, and other UN entities.

There exist various inter-governmental bodies under UNODC which bring together practitioners, policy makers, and other experts from all over the world on the issues of drugs and crime:

- Commission on Narcotic Drugs (CND)
- Commission on Crime Prevention and Criminal Justice (CCPCJ)
- United Nations Congresses on Crime Prevention and Criminal Justice

- Conference of the States Parties to the United Nations Convention against Corruption.²

AGENDA OVERVIEW

Migrant Smuggling is the facilitation, for financial or other material gain, of irregular entry into a country where the migrant is not a national or resident.³ Migrants may often seek illegal means of crossing borders to escape natural disasters, conflict, or poverty linked to these. Migrant smugglers are financially motivated. It is a highly profitable crime for its perpetrators and is considered relatively risk-free for the criminals with regard to law enforcement. Countries differ in policies from rare prosecutions and convictions to instances of local law enforcement focusing more on the persecution of the refugees than the criminals, enabling transport through dangerous, illegal routes, and propagating the dangerous exploitation of migrant workers. Migrant workers face disproportionately high chances of being forced into slavery like conditions due to their recruitment debts, social status, and language barriers. This effect may compound itself into a full-blown slave trade issue when smugglers effectively sell migrants as labourers. The UNODC supports the member states in the implementation and formation of legal frameworks, providing technical assistance and building capacity to combat this pervasive issue.

¹ United Nations: Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.). <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/about-unodc/index.html>

² *Inter-governmental bodies*. United Nations: Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.-b). <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/international-cooperation/inter-governmental-bodies.html>

³ *Migrant smuggling*. United Nations: Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.). <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/migrant-smuggling/migrant-smuggling.html>

BACKGROUND

In the context of migration, the International Organisation for Migration (IOM) defines vulnerable migrants as a group with limited capability to avoid, cope with, and recover from the exploitation that they experience within a migration context and are thus unable to enjoy their human rights.

Some migrants consent to being smuggled; however, during the smuggling process, they may face significant risks and be subjected to violence and abuse. Other migrants, particularly irregular migrants, are vulnerable to mistreatment or exploitation related to their status as migrants. This includes demand for bribes, forced labour, forced sexual acts, kidnap and ransom. In this way, smuggled migrants can become victims of trafficking, and should be understood as vulnerable, even if they consented to the initial smuggling.

Increased vulnerability may also be present when migrants are transiting from or through areas affected by a crisis. This requires various protection needs at different points in the migration journey. In such instances, these needs might not relate to the "category" to which the migrants belonged at the beginning of their journey.

ROOTS AND CAUSES

Scarcity of Formal Support Structures

The scarcity of formal support structures leaves migrants highly vulnerable to smuggling and forced labour. While some laws and practices are intended to protect migrants from abuse and exploitation, many gaps in these mechanisms

leave large areas where people are entirely without protection. These gaps can be actively leveraged by unethical recruiters, agents, employers, and others to extract profit or other personal reward from vulnerable migrants. Even where formal systems exist, corruption, lack of oversight, and the existence of well-entrenched 'shadow systems' undermine protections.

Oversight and enforcement become challenging when the affected people start hiding. This happens especially when there are disincentives for victims to self-identify, like the fear of criminalisation for offences committed while exploited.⁴ Attempting to intercept smuggled migrants and combat the crime places a significant strain on the resources of countries of destination. If countries lack the resources and legal framework to respond appropriately, the crime may continue unchecked.

Commercial Interest

The migration business is conceived as a system of institutionalised networks with complex profit and loss accounts, including a set of institutions, agents, and individuals, each of which wants to make a commercial gain.⁵ According to UNODC estimates, at a minimum, 3 million migrants are smuggled into the United States each year, generating an estimated USD 6.6 billion for criminals annually in the United States alone. Smuggling income for smuggling within the Horn of Africa (primarily consisting of Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia, and Somalia), and from there to North Africa, could range between USD 300 million and USD 500 million per year.⁶

The model is divided into stages:

- the mobilisation and recruitment of migrants;

⁴ Publication authors: Fiona David, Katharine Bryant and Jacqueline Joudo Larsen. (n.d.-d). https://publications.iom.int/system/files/pdf/migrants_and_their_vulnerability.pdf

⁵ Kevin.town. (n.d.-b). *Transnational organized crime: let's put them out of business*. Smuggling of migrants: the harsh search for a better life. <https://www.unodc.org/toc/en/crimes/migrant-smuggling.html>

⁶ Global overview | 1 2018 Global Study on Smuggling of Migrants. (n.d.-b). https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glosom/GLOSOM_2018_web_small.pdf

- their movement en route;
- and their insertion and integration into labour markets and host societies in destination countries.

Many smugglers run legitimate businesses and are involved in the smuggling of migrants as opportunistic carriers or hospitality providers who choose to look the other way in order to make some extra money. Corrupt officials and other individuals may also be involved in the process.

Poverty and Income Inequality

Poverty and income inequality are fundamental drivers of migrant smuggling and forced labour. At a structural level, poverty creates a cycle of vulnerability: poor people are constantly willing to risk unsafe migration, while criminals take advantage of their needs for income by exploiting them. Total illegal profits generated from forced labour amount to an estimated USD 236 billion annually, resulting from almost USD 10,000 profit per victim.⁷ Underpayment is a common feature of forced labour and a critical driver of profits from it. Across all sectors, workers classified as seasonal and casual workers are frequently excluded from minimum wage protection granted to regular workers, leaving them especially vulnerable to underpayment.

MIGRATION

Smuggling Routes

Migrant smuggling routes are constantly in flux, but often meet at centers of activity. Where geography permits, land routes are commonly employed, more so than sea or air smuggling routes that tend to be more resource- and organisation-intensive.



Map of smuggling routes

Source: UNODC GLOSOM report

A very high percentage of migrants smuggled from the Horn of Africa to Southern Africa, for instance, travel by land. Of 400 migrants polled, 10 per cent used air transport, whereas just 1 per cent used sea routes.⁸ Despite global efforts to stem trafficking along these routes, their flexibility continues to erode efforts implemented by states, exposing migrants to danger while in transit and upon arrival. Although routes shift, smuggling hubs - where the supply and demand for smuggling services intersect - are relatively fixed over time. Often, smuggling hubs are capitals or major cities, but can also be isolated towns where most of the economic activity is based around migrant smuggling. Agadez in Niger, for instance, is a staging post for recent smuggling traffic, with hundreds of thousands having planned their journey from West Africa to North Africa (and Europe) there. Approximately 65,000 migrants were said to have departed from Agadez for North Africa in 2003.⁹

Border Control

Border control is an essential aspect of the control of smuggling of migrants, but it also serves to reveal the link between state security and humanitarian responsibilities. Illegal crossings have been reduced by one-third in a year,

⁷ Profits and poverty: The Economics of Forced Labour. (n.d.-c). https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2024-10/Profits%20and%20poverty%20-%20The%20economics%20of%20forced%20labour_WEB_20241017.pdf

⁸ Global overview | 11 2018 Global Study on Smuggling of Migrants. (n.d.-e). https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glosom/GLOSOM_2018_web_small.pdf

⁹ UNODC. (n.d.-q). https://www.unodc.org/documents/human-trafficking/Migrant-Smuggling/Report_SOM_West_Africa_EU.pdf

according to Frontex in Europe, as the EU tightened its belt on migration, particularly along the Central Mediterranean and Western Balkan routes. In the United States of America, visa restrictions have been levied on Colombian maritime firms on suspicion of transporting migrants via the Darien Gap towards Panama.¹⁰ The actions undertaken come under fire for forcing migrants on unsafe routes or violating their asylum rights. Nevertheless, it highlights the high dependence of states on border control as a deterrent and enforcement.

LABOUR

Bondage and Slave Labour

Bondage and Slave labor are threats to migrant laborers, particularly in labor markets with weaker legal enforcement. The International Labour Organisation (ILO) has estimated that nearly 28 million workers globally have been trapped and coerced by debt bondage, document confiscation, and threats of deportation.¹¹ UNODC has reported incidents of smuggled migrants being exploited in agriculture or domestic work under conditions tantamount to modern-day slavery. As a result of the persistence of systemic weaknesses, millions of migrants are condemned to live under exploitative systems of labour.

Unethical Recruitment

The unethical recruitment of migrant labour is a widespread issue tied to labour exploitation and cross-border organised crime. Migrants are frequently deceived about work environments, transportation safety, and assurance of pay.

Recruiters in rural or war-torn areas frequently employ deceptive advertising, enticing job offers or loans that result in debt bondage, guaranteeing reliance on their kidnappers. Migrant workers are generally charged exorbitant fees. Indian workers heading for the Gulf were made to pay, on average, USD 1430 in recruitment and processing costs. Most of that money was covered by loans. The Bangladesh to Malaysia migration fee was documented at USD 5000. These debts make the low-wage workers highly susceptible to coercion and debt bondage. Those unable to pay these debts are forced to work for free to repay the initial recruitment fees. According to a study carried out by UNW and the IOM, along with the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation, thousands of women migrant workers labor under contracts they don't understand, in languages they cannot read, or that provide inadequate protection of their rights. Lack of written evidence, high cost of legal assistance, fear of retaliation, and language barriers are among the challenges to accessing justice.

Kafala System

The Kafala system is the Middle Eastern legal system governing the employment and residence status of migrant workers in relation to their employers. It ties a migrant worker's employment and residence status legally to one sponsor (employer).¹² The sponsor typically controls the visa, and often the worker cannot change jobs or leave the country without the sponsor's permission.

¹⁰ Actions Against Executives of Colombian Maritime Transportation Companies that Facilitate Irregular Migration. (n.d.-c). <https://pa.usembassy.gov/actions-against-executives-of-colombian-maritime-transportation-companies-that-facilitate-irregular-migration/>

¹¹ ILO. (n.d.-g). https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/wcmsp5/groups/public/@ed_norm/@ipec/documents/publication/wcms_854795.pdf

¹² Council on Foreign Relations. (n.d.). *What is the kafala system?* Council on Foreign Relations. <https://www.cfr.org/backgrounder/what-kafala-system>

network, and the links are similar to those of business relations.

Other smugglers belong to large and well-organised hierarchical criminal operations with transnational links and the capability of organising sophisticated smuggling passages that might involve the use of falsified or fraudulently obtained travel documents. Often, such smuggling is sold as 'packages' that involve migrants travelling long distances, using multiple modes of transportation. The inclusion of financial or other material benefit as a constitutive element of the migrant smuggling crime is also a common affair in the smuggling of Migrants.

Lack of Labour Standards

Adequate wages and timely payment are essential for securing decent work and social justice, and have the most direct and tangible effect on the everyday lives of workers. Countless families and communities are dependent on remittances from migrant worker relatives. Migrant workers may face discrimination, xenophobia, and racism, unfair recruitment processes, and restrictions based on their migration status, which can contribute to labour and wage-related abuses. The issue of non-payment of wages is one of the most common forms of complaints by low-wage migrant workers, especially workers in irregular status.

Victim Identification

Instead of being identified as victims of a serious human rights violation, many times, victims are arrested, detained, denied assistance, and protection. They are even forcibly returned to

countries of origin because of racial profiling and discrimination at border crossings and in criminal justice systems. Prevention measures are also limited by racist stereotyping and xenophobia and lead to failures of identification.

Current migrant disaster victim identification processes appear to be inadequate and underfunded – approximately 22% of deceased migrants are never identified.¹⁶ Lack of identification is not confined to those who have been forcibly displaced. The nationality of the ones who have been forcibly displaced can be unclear. For example, more than 80% of those who have fled from Nigeria to Niger to escape Boko Haram have no documents of any kind, but are potentially entitled to nationality in either country.¹⁷

Maritime Smuggling

In and around some smuggling hubs and departure areas for maritime routes, systematic torture of migrants, extortion, exploitation and fatalities have been widely reported. Migrants have been dumped into the sea by smugglers, and migrants have faced brutal violence, torture, rape, and abduction, either in transit or captivity, but law enforcers do little to stop these crimes, according to a report released by the UNODC in 2024.¹⁸

The 1979 International Convention on Maritime Search and Rescue (SAR Convention) obliges State Parties to 'ensure that assistance is provided to any person in distress at sea, regardless of the nationality or status of such a person or the circumstances in which that person is found'. Smugglers sometimes take advantage of this basic humanitarian and legal principle by

¹⁶ MDVI. (n.d.). <https://migrant-dvi.eu/>

¹⁷ Identification in the context of forced displacement. (n.d.).

<https://documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/375811469772770030/pdf/Identification-in-the-Context-of-Forced-Displacement-Identification-for-Development-ID4D.pdf>

¹⁸ *Global report on trafficking in persons*. United Nations: Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.-a).

<https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/global-report-on-trafficking-in-persons.html>

exposing migrants to the imminent risk of drowning.



Maritime Smuggling

Source: International Maritime Organisation

For example, more than 660,000 irregular migrants enter Thailand each year from neighbouring countries, and, based on field research, more than 80% of them use the assistance of smugglers. This indicates that about 550,000 migrants are smuggled from these countries into Thailand each year.¹⁹

INITIATIVES AND COLLABORATIONS

GOALS Programme with IMO, ILO, and UNW

The International Maritime Organisation (IMO) has established joint working groups with the International Labour Organisation (ILO) on seafarer issues. In 2022, IMO and ILO established the Joint ILO/IMO Tripartite Working Group (JTWG) to identify and Address Seafarers' Issues and the Human Element. Violence and harassment in the maritime sector, including sexual assault and sexual harassment.

The Joint ILO/IMO Tripartite Working Group was instructed to "consider bullying and harassment in the maritime sector, including sexual assault and harassment, taking into account information

submitted by interested parties, with a view to providing recommendations for future steps, including the development of legislation, mechanisms and policies, and the launching of awareness campaigns by relevant stakeholders, aimed at reporting and addressing these matters".

IMO has the Women in Maritime Associations (WIMAs) in various regions and also the "SMART-C Women" project. Their common aim is to support women professionals in the maritime sector in ASEAN & Pacific regions, with skills in environmental and digital technologies. This enhances women's representation and career progression in maritime technical/leadership roles.

Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration

The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration (GCM), was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in December 2018.

Contrary to a binding treaty, the Compact is a non-legally binding cooperative system, based on international human rights law, to enhance migration governance, decrease irregular migration, and uphold the protection of migrants' rights. It establishes 23 goals, such as improving data collection, reducing drivers of forced migration, ensuring ethical recruitment, fighting smuggling and trafficking, increasing regular migration channels, and enhancing international cooperation. The Compact has been welcomed for setting a global migration vision based on human dignity and responsibility-sharing, but also criticised, in particular by some states who claimed it had the potential to erode national sovereignty over border control. However, through the UN Network on Migration, the implementation has

¹⁹ Everyone's prey: Kidnapping and extortionate detention in mixed migration. (n.d.-a). https://mixedmigration.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/07/068_everyones_preys.pdf

progressed with the coordination of assistance to governments and civil society actors. The success of the GCM finally relies on voluntary state obligation, multilateral coordination, and the inclusion of its goals in national migration legislation and labour systems.

Palermo Protocol

The Palermo Protocols, adopted by the UN in 2000 and enforced in 2003, are the three protocols of the UNTOC, which are as follows:

- The Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and Children,²⁰
- The Protocol Against the Smuggling of Migrants by Land, Sea, and Air²¹
- The Protocol Against the Illicit Manufacturing of and Trafficking in Firearms.²²

These are aimed at preventing the trafficking and exploitation of labour as well as defining the punishment of the perpetrators. The protocol commits ratifying states to combat trafficking in persons, protecting and assisting victims of trafficking, and promoting cooperation among states to meet those objectives.

CASE STUDIES

USA-Mexico Border Crisis

Mexico is a key country of origin, transit, and destination for migrant smuggling and forced labor. The United States-Mexico border is the world's deadliest as well as the most crossed land route for migrants, with at least 686 deaths and disappearances in 2022.²³ The majority of the

migrants who cross this border do it with the help of professional smugglers. But often these agreements evolve into a trafficking situation. In Mexico, these illegal flows have fuelled extreme levels of armed conflict among organised criminal groups.

Throughout the Americas, 1,457 migrant deaths and disappearances were recorded in 2022, the deadliest year on record, according to IOM.



USA-Mexico Border
Source: New York Times

Some studies have estimated that about 392,000 Central American migrants were smuggled to Mexico and onwards to the United States in 2014, and 377,000 in 2015. Only 11% managed to reach their final destination in the United States, while most (56%) were intercepted and recorded by United States border authorities, and 33% were detected and recorded by the Mexican authorities.

In Mexico, the total number of detections involving Central American migrants increased from 61,000 in 2010 to 132,000 in 2015 and 151,000 in 2016. In 2016, the number of Central Americans decreased, and at the same time, the

²⁰ Protocol to prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons Especially Women and Children, supplementing the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organised Crime. (n.d.-p).

<https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/ProtocolonTrafficking.pdf>

²¹ Protocol against the smuggling of migrants by land, sea and air. (n.d.-o).

https://www.unodc.org/documents/middleeastandnorthafrica/smuggling-migrants/SoM_Protocol_English.pdf

²² The firearms protocol. United Nations: Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.-c).

<https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/firearms-protocol/the-firearms-protocol.html>

²³ US-Mexico border world's deadliest migration land route | international organization for migration. (n.d.-h).

<https://www.iom.int/news/us-mexico-border-worlds-deadliest-migration-land-route>

number of detected migrants from Caribbean countries increased.²⁴

Recent reports suggest that migrants seeking to cross the Mexico-US border can be charged between USD 7,000 and USD 18,000 to be smuggled, and that cartels may be generating a combined revenue of between USD 4 billion and USD 12 billion a year from such operations.²⁵

Rohingya Crisis, Myanmar

The Rohingya are a muslim minority from Rakhine, Myanmar. In 2017, the Burmese military's "clearance operation" displaced over 700,000 Rohingya refugees to Bangladesh. Bangladesh houses effectively 1.5 million refugees, with half of that figure being children.

In Myanmar, forced labour remains systemic. An ILO commission found that Rohingya were coerced into portering often in extremely dangerous conditions, including minefields, road construction, and other infrastructure work.²⁶ This work is frequently unpaid and accompanied by physical abuse and a lack of compensation. These abuses continue in the places where Rohingya seek refuge. In Bangladesh's camps in Cox's Bazar, refugees are largely barred from formal employment, and many children are forced into menial labour.



Rohingya refugees climb off a boat arriving in Bangladesh

Source: UNHCR

According to the U.S. Department of Labor reports, Rohingya children work in construction, fishing, shops, and fish drying industries; some are underpaid or unpaid, while others engage in bonded labour to service debts owed by parents. During the COVID-19 pandemic, child labour increased in both the Rohingya and the host community. A study found a roughly 16 per cent rise in working children among Rohingya households, and 49 per cent in host community households, alongside increased rates of early marriage²⁷. Many are held in squalid conditions, face exploitation, or are forced into dangerous work such as fishing on cargo ships or boats far from shore. Women and girls from the Rohingya community are particularly vulnerable to sexual exploitation; reports indicate that children are promised domestic service but are trafficked instead for commercial sexual exploitation in Bangladesh, India, and Nepal.

²⁴ Global overview | 1 2018 Global Study on Smuggling of Migrants. (n.d.-a).

https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glosom/GLOSOM_2018_web_small.pdf

²⁵ Pandit, P. (2025a, May 27). *The Mexico-US border and its impact on peacefulness*. Vision of Humanity.

<https://www.visionofhumanity.org/the-mexico-us-border-and-its-impact-on-peacefulness/>

²⁶ ILO Towards Freedom and Dignity in Myanmar. (n.d.-j).

https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/wcmsp5/groups/public/@ed_norm/@relconf/documents/publication/wcms_894548.pdf

²⁷ Un migration agency warns of trafficking, labour exploitation, sexual abuse of Rohingya refugees | International Organization for Migration. (n.d.-t). <https://www.iom.int/news/un-migration-agency-warns-trafficking-labour-exploitation-sexual-abuse-rohingya-refugees>

2022 Qatar FIFA World Cup

Qatar was named the location of the 2022 FIFA World Cup in December 2010, becoming the first country in the Middle East to be named a host. Qatar spared no cost, spending upwards of USD 220 billion on revitalising the city, building the required infrastructure, including several stadiums.²⁸ However, the kafala system became more prevalent than ever. The migrant workforce in Qatar is estimated at 2 million, making up nearly 95% of the labor force in a country of just 3 million people. Qatar has the highest ratio of migrants in the world. 85% of its population are migrants.²⁹ Qatar's government said that 30,000 foreign labourers were hired just to build the stadiums.³⁰ The attention increased particularly after reports of the death of some workers came out. The government said its accident records showed that between 2014 and 2020, there were 37 deaths. However, the ILO contradicted and said 50 foreign labourers died and more than 500 others were seriously injured in 2021 alone, while another 37,600 suffered mild to moderate injuries.

Qatar's labour court has been very slow in resolving cases brought by migrant workers who were cheated out of their wages. Some migrant workers have tried to sue companies in jurisdictions outside Qatar. Forty Filipino migrant workers recently filed a lawsuit against Jacobs Solutions Inc., a US firm that oversaw construction projects for four World Cup stadiums, for multiple alleged abuses, including unpaid wages, cramped living conditions, passport confiscation, and working in extreme heat. The desire for a spectacle allowed safety and labour procedures to be overlooked, and

with tight deadlines taking priority over basic human rights.

MAJOR ACTORS

Cambodia

The Cambodian government promotes labour migration, but the lack of a straightforward, speedy, affordable, and transparent formal system for regular migration makes Cambodian migrants vulnerable to exploitation both in Cambodia and in destination countries. Key reasons include the absence of: a cheap and effective system for migration that protects potential migrants from trafficking and exploitation; a justice system capable of holding to account those in positions of power who profit most from these actions; and sufficient resources allocated to ensure appropriate assistance to victims.

This is primarily driven by socio-economic factors. People facing economic hardships consider migration as an apt way to address their situation. A 2016 study found that the 3 most common reasons that migrants leave Cambodia were having 'No job', 'Low income', and 'Financial debt'. In 2016, an IOM survey of returned Cambodian migrants found that 41% of the respondents noted financial debt as the main reason for seeking work abroad.³¹ Although Thailand is the main destination for Cambodian labour migrants, Cambodian women and men are also migrating to other Asian and Middle Eastern countries for work-related purposes.

²⁸ By. (2025, February 10). Sussex Centre for Migration Research Blog. <https://blogs.sussex.ac.uk/sussex-centre-for-migration-research/2025/02/10/2022worldcup/>

²⁹ The 2022 FIFA World Cup in Qatar: Turning the spotlight on workers' rights: Think tank: European parliament. Think Tank European Parliament. (n.d.).

https://www.europarl.europa.eu/thinktank/en/document/EPRS_BRI%282021%29698856

³⁰ BBC. (2022, November 9). World Cup 2022: How has Qatar treated foreign workers? BBC News.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-60867042>

³¹ ODI. (n.d.-b). https://media.odi.org/documents/An_analysis_of_Cambodia.pdf

Libya

The situation in Libya appears to be unique, given the historic role of this country in the smuggling of migrants in combination with its unstable political situation and insecurity. Contacts or cooperation between smuggling networks and militia groups in Libya have been reported, and some of the armed groups in that country are allegedly involved in different types of criminal activity, including migrant smuggling.

Libya was an important destination and transit country for smuggled migrants from the Horn of Africa, but recently, this flow has drastically diminished. Before the deterioration of the security situation in the Kufra district in Libya in 2012, the Kufra governor estimated the flows from Sudan into the district at 10,000-12,000 people per month, whereas in 2013, a significant reduction of the flow was recorded, and only 300-1,000 migrants were estimated to enter Libya from Sudan per month.³²

Although many of these arrivals may not apply for asylum, data on asylum applications in Libya also reflect the decreasing flow from countries in the Horn of Africa into Libya.

United Arab Emirates

In the UAE, migrant workers are trapped in exploitative conditions with disregard for their safety and conditions, with bonded labour under Kafala system-like labour contracts. Migrant workers comprise more than 80% of the UAE's population. Although UAE labor laws stipulate a maximum of eight working hours per day and 48 hours per week, these regulations are frequently flouted.³³ Problems regarding sex trafficking, violence against migrants, paperwork confiscation, and wage theft are widely reported

on. The official position includes labour law adjustments, prosecution of trafficking cases, and worker complaint mechanisms.

Humanitarian crises persist regarding worker rights, with the Human Rights Watch noting lapses in the implementation and enforcement of these policies. While legal frameworks exist, there is a disparity between the workers' reality and the proposed reforms.

IMPACTS

Exploitation of Cheap, Illegal labour

Exporting manufacturing and menial labour has always been an effective way to curb expenses. With the increase in the scale of global commerce and highly competitive capitalistic markets, there is a massive rise in the usage of migrant workers. High consumer demand makes it nearly impossible to ethically source labour and be in line with market trends; the system dictates that a certain amount of sacrifice in morals must be made to thrive at scale. Migrant labour does exactly that. In doing so, one opens the door to the realm of crime rings and complex supply chains regarding smuggled workers. It soon turns into a human rights issue with the exploitation of labourers throughout the world. Worker conditions degrade, and along with them does their compensation. Migrant workers are treated as sub-human with slave-like conditions. Companies showed blatant disregard for their safety and rights.

According to the ILO, around 27.6 million people are in forced labour, leading to over USD 236 billion being generated in illegal profit every year, 3.9 million of which are in a state-imposed form of forced labour. A 2022 global estimate places migrants at 3 times more risk of forced

³² UNODC. (n.d.-d). https://www.unodc.org/documents/data-and-analysis/glosom/GLOSOM_2018_Africa_web_small.pdf

³³ *World Report 2025: Rights trends in the United Arab Emirates*. Human Rights Watch. (2025, January 16). <https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2025/country-chapters/united-arab-emirates>

labour relative to the local workforce. Smuggling occurs through dangerous and militarised routes. Welfare of labourers is ignored en route as well as in situ. These labourers, usually impoverished, are made to work in harmful conditions which do not aid their enrichment. Due to the change in commerce from a local niche self-manufactured style to vast cross-border logistical nightmares, labour exploitation has become all too familiar in the modern world.

Corruption and Destabilisation of the Government

Corruption and weak governance play a major role in the spread of migrant smuggling and forced labour. When officials collude with criminal networks or fail to enforce the law, these crimes grow stronger. Such practices weaken state institutions, reduce public trust, and make it harder to protect vulnerable people. This instability encourages criminals to exploit migration systems and threaten national and regional security.

The United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC) identifies several conduct as corruption which should be treated as serious crimes, including:

- Bribery in the public and private sectors.
- Trading in influence.
- Abuse of functions.³⁴

Corruption can occur at both high and low levels, from ministers, diplomats, and consular officials to border guards, police officers, or cleaning staff at airports. At the higher level, for example, visa-issuing authorities and immigration directors may be offered bribes and benefits to provide a service or to turn a blind eye. At the lower level, immigration, security, airport, and airline staff may be paid to do something as small as

stamping a document without closely inspecting it or unlocking a door.

Humanitarian Crisis with Poor Worker Conditions

Smuggled migrants are often subject to grave human rights abuses. During transit, people might be squeezed into exceptionally small spaces in trucks or onto unseaworthy boats in order for smugglers to maximize their 'cargo'.³⁵

Once they reach their destination, many find that they and/or their families are the victims of blackmail or debt bondage. The latter involves them paying huge sums of money to criminals to settle insurmountable levels of debt out of fear of violence or of being deported by the authorities. The smuggling of migrants has an impact on the countries of origin, transit, and destination. In countries of origin, families go into debt to pay the smuggling fee, with no guarantee for a return on their investment, and may even be left with no news from their relatives, not knowing whether they are dead or alive, in prison, or victims of trafficking. In transit countries, smuggled migrants may become stranded with limited means of continuing their journey or be deceived by smugglers.

CONCLUSION

Migrant smuggling is a transnational issue plaguing the various states of origin and exploitation. Smuggling routes weave through gaps in international patrols and are constantly evolving to combat the preventative measures. Migrants are exploited, face long hours, violence, and threats of deportation. It remains highly profitable for its perpetrators, especially when repercussions for the crime remain low. The

³⁴ *Corruption and the smuggling of migrants - issue paper*. United Nations: Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.-b).

https://www.unodc.org/documents/human-trafficking/2013/The_Role_Of_Corruption_in_the_Smuggling_of_Migrants_Issue_Paper_UNODC_2013.pdf

³⁵ Kevin.town. (n.d.). *Transnational organized crime: let's put them out of business*. Smuggling of migrants: the harsh search for a better life. <https://www.unodc.org/toc/en/crimes/migrant-smuggling.html>

exploitation of migrant workers serves as a massive labour force, who are treated as essentially disposable. Basic human rights are violated, and states and private organisations profit from the backs of migrants, usually refugees from conflict, natural disasters, or poverty. There is a severe need for a legal framework built on the consensus of nations to combat and resolve this issue. The lack of culpability for the organised rings propagating this systemic issue is a legal and criminal problem. Global cooperation is the key to effectively dealing with the problem at scale;

state-led international initiatives are required to resolve the situation in a humane and prompt manner.

Agenda 2: Combating Transnational Organised Fraud and Digital Exploitation

AGENDA OVERVIEW

According to the UNODC, transnational organised fraud and digital exploitation refers to serious, profit-motivated criminal activities that cross national borders, leveraging advanced technologies and digital means. This can include cybercrime, money laundering, and other forms of fraud that are used by criminal groups to generate profits that are aided by globalization and easy communication.³⁶

Cybercrime is an evolving form of transnational crime. Culprits of cybercrime/digital exploitation and their victims can be located in different regions, and their effects can ripple through societies around the world, highlighting the need to launch an urgent international response. These include offenses against computer data and systems, such as hacking and malware; computer-related offenses, including identity theft, fraud, and phishing; and content-related offenses, like child sexual abuse and distribution of extremist content, along with related offenses such as copyright infringement. Another big problem is cryptocurrency and an array of illicit activities like drug trafficking, gambling, intellectual property theft, money laundering, human and wildlife trafficking, associated with it.³⁷

UNODC promotes long-term and sustainable capacity building in the fight against cybercrime

through supporting national structures and action.

It aims to provide technical assistance and training to states to improve national legislation in order to prevent, detect, investigate, and prosecute such crime in all its forms.³⁸

BACKGROUND

The digital age has ushered in unprecedented connectivity, with over 60% of the world's population now online. However, this interconnectedness has also brought with it a surge in cybercrime, impacting individuals, institutions, and countries globally.

Cybercrime encompasses a wide range of offences, from online fraud and data theft to the exploitation of children. Perpetrators range from individual criminals to organised networks, all exploiting the anonymity and accessibility of the digital world. The methods used are constantly evolving, becoming more sophisticated and harder to detect. Malware is proliferating. AI-enabled cyber operations are amplifying the threat, while the looming potential of quantum computing to break encryption poses a significant risk to cybersecurity infrastructure.

One alarming trend is the rise of ransomware attacks, which cripple vital systems and hold data hostage. In 2023 alone, ransomware payments reached an estimated USD 1.1 billion. These attacks disrupt essential services like healthcare and banking, and erode public trust and safety.

³⁶ Kevin.town. (n.d.-b). *Transnational organised crime: let's put them out of business*. Transnational organised crime: the globalized illegal economy. <https://www.unodc.org/toc/en/crimes/organized-crime.html>

³⁷ *Money laundering through cryptocurrencies*. United Nations: UN Toolkit on Synthetic Drugs. (n.d.). <https://syntheticdrugs.unodc.org/syntheticdrugs/en/cybercrime/laundryingproceeds/moneylaundering.html>

³⁸ *Cybercrime*. United Nations: UNODC ROMENA. (n.d.). <https://www.unodc.org/romena/en/cybercrime.html>

CYBERCRIME

Digital Marketplaces

The UNODC has identified the multibillion-dollar cyberscam industry, which has emerged strongly in South-East Asia and has expanded globally, especially in Africa and South America. Online marketplaces and commerce hubs play a crucial role in the proliferation of illicit material through unregulated channels. Untraceable financial flows and a lack of moderation are key tenets leading to the popularity of these marketplaces. State actors have established underground banking systems, casinos, and cryptocurrency exchanges, facilitating the laundering of profits from cybercrime.

Phishing, Trojans

Phishing refers to a particular type of cybercrime involving social engineering and manipulating victims to give up access codes, credentials, or authorize transfers. Phishing is a core first step for large-scale transnational fraud. With the advent of Artificial Intelligence, the barrier to entry to create convincing and targeted phishing campaigns has been considerably lowered. This allows relatively smaller-scale operations to have a wider target scope while retaining the specificity required for social engineering. Trojans serve as a second point of entry for cybercrime. Seemingly benign files and programs operate covertly to serve as keyloggers, session hijacks, and other entry paths into financial systems or remote access.

Pig-Butchering

Pig butchering, originating in 2016 and being expanded during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, refers to the combination of romance/grooming scams and false investment platforms (usually cryptocurrency). Scammers

build trust with victims through tailored conversations, usually following a given script meant to be broad-spectrum. These acts tend to be highly manipulative and coerce victims to be amicable towards their perpetrators. This process is analogous to “fattening the pig”. The latter half of this scam, i.e., the “slaughter,” consists of pressuring targets to make unsound financial decisions by investing in risky assets, typically through a false third-party exchange. Scams tend to include bogus financial dashboards, enticing rates of returns on investments that will never pay out, and time-based pressure tactics. This type of crime has gained prevalence in South-East Asia and China and tends to target socially isolated or older victims, leading to a higher victim acquisition rate.

Illicit Surveillance

Monitoring of communication data serves as a privacy violation and an effective tool of surveillance for actors as small as individuals to nation-states. The usage of wiretaps has drastically reduced, with advances in surveillance technology ranging from commercial systems like Pegasus to fake cell towers. International Mobile Subscriber Identity (IMSI) stingrays harvest metadata to identify, locate, and track people. Bespoke malware is delivered on a system-by-system basis via phishing. Law enforcement overreach and humanitarian crises due to the threat of surveillance on journalists and sources cause harm, especially because of the lack of legal remedies for victims.³⁹

CHALLENGES

Jurisdictional Complexity

It is technically challenging to associate the dark web with specific jurisdictions and geographical boundaries. The dark web is a hidden part of the internet that cannot be indexed by regular search

³⁹ US: *Surveillance harming journalism, law, democracy*. Human Rights Watch. (2024, January) <https://www.hrw.org/news/2014/07/28/us-surveillance-harming-journalism-law-democracy>

engines. It is accessed through specialized browsers like Tor, which offers anonymity to the users.. It sometimes takes investigation and prosecution of specific cases to identify which countries the criminals are operating from. Organised crime groups are converging and exploiting vulnerabilities, and the evolving situation is rapidly outpacing governments' capacity to contain it. According to UNODC, the surge in criminality has been driven by organised crime groups in the region, which operate in a remarkably open way.

Arms Race between Law Enforcement and Criminals

Criminal networks are increasingly leveraging cutting-edge tools, such as encryption, AI, robotics, darknet environments, cryptocurrencies, and cross-border digital platforms to outpace law enforcement capabilities. UNODC's Darknet Cybercrime Threats to Southeast Asia underscores how darknets facilitate attacks with high levels of anonymity, forcing criminal actors to stay one step ahead in terms of evasion techniques.

This accelerating arms race creates friction between threat evolution and operational readiness. As criminals adopt tools and tactics faster, often exploiting jurisdictions with weak oversight, leveraging global digital infrastructure, or hiding behind anonymity, law enforcement agencies face capacity constraints: gaps in technology, legal authority, international cooperation, and human rights compliance. UNODC's work in India, for example, shows that authorities are pushing to build skills in darknet investigations and cryptocurrency tracing in response to fraud, money laundering, and cyber extortion threats.

Lack of Public Awareness

Lack of awareness is a powerful weapon that the offenders use to cause harm to people. A large proportion of the public and Small and Medium-sized Enterprises (SMEs) vastly underestimate the risk of cybercrime and feel powerless to protect themselves against it. There is a widespread misconception that cyber criminals focus only on big businesses and celebrities rather than 'ordinary' people. This might be due to Lack of Engagement, Outdated or Irrelevant Content and Training Methods, Inadequate metrics, etc. In 2024, one in three people who reported fraud said they lost money, adding up to USD 12.5 billion (up by USD 2.5 billion from 2023). People lost more money per person (a median of USD 1,500) when they interacted with scammers on the phone. A majority (79%) of people who reported an investment-related scam lost money, with a median loss of over USD 9,000.⁴⁰

Encryption and Codes

Encryption is the process of transforming readable plain text into unreadable ciphertext to mask sensitive information from unauthorised users. Organisations regularly use encryption in data security to protect sensitive data from unauthorized access and data breaches.⁴¹ But encryption breaches are a common phenomenon. Breaking encryption typically involves attempting to discover the secret key that was used to encrypt a message. Once discovered, it can be used to decrypt the original message, making it readable. Some common misuses of encryption in fraudulent activities are encrypted transactions and malicious data exfiltration, holding digital assets hostage, increased darknet activities, etc.

⁴⁰ Staff, B., & Staff, B. (2025, March 10). *Top scams of 2024*. Consumer Advice. <https://consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2025/03/top-scams-2024>

⁴¹ Google. (n.d.). *What is encryption and how does it work?* | google cloud. Google. <https://cloud.google.com/learn/what-is-encryption>

IMPACTS

Large-scale Fiscal Losses

The FBI has reported that the cost of cybercrime in 2024 rose to USD 16 billion at a minimum.⁴² German companies have faced losses of USD 300 billion in the 2023-2024 financial year.⁴³ Cyberattacks cost UK businesses USD 55 billion in the past 5 years. The global repercussions of cybercrime have been felt in most markets. Cybercrime causes an erosion of trust in financial foundations. Vulnerabilities in banking systems serve as key entry points into fraud and hacking. Targeted attacks on large-scale financial infrastructure cause broader systemic risks. While cybersecurity concerns higher operational risk to businesses of all scales, vulnerabilities are far more common in smaller businesses due to poor awareness and countermeasures.

Psychological Fallout

The victims of Cybercrime tend to be socially marginalised individuals, including the elderly and the tech-illiterate. The proliferation of scams that focus on identity theft, romance scams, and sextortion causes the development of a social stigma around victims. Paranoia, hypervigilance, and acute stress symptoms are common responses to public exposure of private data, doxxing, and cyberstalking. The anonymity provided by the internet leads to slander and libel being consequence-free crimes. Reputational and financial damages have driven victims to extreme measures like suicide. The

criminalization of cyberspace is making people fearful of technology.

Damage to Financial Institutions

According to UNODC, the growing trend of organised crime groups utilizing under-regulated online gambling platforms and high-risk Virtual Asset Service Providers (VASPs) to facilitate the movement, laundering, and integration of billions in criminal proceeds into the financial system without accountability.⁴⁴ UNODC estimated financial losses between USD 18 billion and USD 37 billion from scams targeting victims in East and Southeast Asia in 2023 alone, with a high proportion of these losses attributed to scams committed by organised crime groups in Southeast Asia.⁴⁵

Creation of Anonymity-driven Safe Havens for Crime and Illegal trade

Anonymity enables many illegal activities to take place such as tax evasion, corruption, money laundering, and financing of terrorism. It allows the trade in illegal products and services on cryptomarkets to flourish in spite of being enacted in a public location; in plain sight of law enforcement. Their public location makes the cryptomarket trade accessible to anyone so inclined and with an internet connection to observe and do so legally.⁴⁶ Examples of anonymity networks are The Onion Router (also known as Tor), Freenet, and the Invisible Internet Project.

⁴² 2024 IC3 Annual Report. (n.d.-a).

https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2024_IC3Report.pdf

⁴³ FBI releases annual internet crime report | Federal Bureau of Investigation. (n.d.-a).

<https://www.fbi.gov/news/press-releases/fbi-releases-annual-internet-crime-report>

⁴⁴ June 2024 targeted update on implementation of the FATF standards on Virtual. (n.d.-o). <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/content/dam/fatf-gafi/recommendations/2024-Targeted-Update-VA-VASP.pdf.coredownload.inline.pdf>

⁴⁵ Transnational organised crime and the convergence of ... (n.d.-d).

https://www.unodc.org/roseap/uploads/documents/Publications/2024/TOC_Convergence_Report_2024.pdf

⁴⁶ Manchester. (n.d.-g).

https://pure.manchester.ac.uk/ws/portalfiles/portal/87504635/Online_anonymity_AAM_29_March_2019.pdf

INITIATIVES

UNGA Adoption of the Cybercrime Convention

The UN adopted the United Nations Convention against Cybercrime; Strengthening International Cooperation for Combating Certain Crimes Committed by Means of Information and Communications Technology Systems and for the Sharing of Evidence in Electronic Form of Serious Crimes in 2024 under resolution 79/243⁴⁷. It serves as the first comprehensive global treaty on Cybercrime under the UN. It aims to combat cybercrime in all its forms and establish modernized and standardized international legal frameworks. The treaty was drafted by an ad-hoc committee established earlier by the UNGA and took 5 years to negotiate effectively. It includes human rights safeguards; however, critics argue that certain parts are too vague and may leave room for potential misuse.

INTERPOL Collaborations

INTERPOL and the United Nations Department of Peace Operations (UNDPO) have coordinated with one another on several initiatives aimed at supporting national police agencies in developing the capacity and integrity needed to uphold the rule of law. For example, INTERPOL assists the UN Police, specifically the Serious and Organised Crimes unit, with their Transnational Threats Project. This collaboration enables UN field missions to better address transnational threats, including serious and organised crime, corruption, and violent extremism.

INTERPOL further works with the Police Division and its Serious and Organised Crime Team to strengthen the role of police in international peacekeeping; we benefit from the support of the UN in local capacity building, and in return, the

UN endorses our Policing Capabilities in host countries.

In the framework of the GLACY+ project, a joint project of the European Union and the Council of Europe, INTERPOL hosted the 6th Digital Security Challenge in Cebu, Philippines, from 19 to 23 February 2024. This unique capture-the-flag competition was designed to hone the digital forensic and investigative skills of law enforcement personnel from across the globe. The Digital Security Challenge 2024 provided a valuable platform for law enforcement professionals to enhance their understanding of emerging cyber threats by fostering collaboration with international colleagues and strategic problem-solving.

Emergency Response Network (ERN)

The UNODC established an Emergency Response Network (ERN) in South East Asia to combat human trafficking with a special focus on forced criminality in scam operations. Financed by the Government of Japan, it focuses on the rapid communication among law enforcement, INTERPOL, and local bureaus to coordinate the rescue of victims, the dismantlement of organised rings, and conduct investigations. The member states include Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, the Philippines, Thailand, and Vietnam. It was launched in 2012 as part of the global programme on cybercrime.

FRONTEX Collaboration

For years, Frontex has been at the frontline of the fight against document and identity fraud. To assist Member States in tackling document and identity fraud, Frontex established the Centre of Excellence in Combating Document Fraud (CED) in 2018. The Centre provides document and identity control expertise, supporting the

⁴⁷ United Nations. (n.d.). Resolution adopted by the General Assembly on 24 December 2024.
<https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/79/243>

processing of persons at the external borders of the European Union. It acts as the primary entity for supporting operational response of related field activities, ensuring the rapid deployment of the Frontex Document Fraud Team within 48 hours to assist in emergencies related to document fraud.⁴⁸

For frontline officers in charge of document authentication and confronted with new forgery phenomena, the Centre developed a reference manual containing document forgery alerts and Quick Check Cards (QCC) to serve as visual decision aids highlighting the key security features to be checked in a document. The reference manual offers concrete support in determining the authenticity of the document under scrutiny. The agency expanded its presence in this area, becoming responsible for the operation of the False and Authentic Documents Online system (FADO), which is operated by the CED. Thanks to FADO, a border guard will need only seconds to verify an ID, a driver's, or a vehicle license.⁴⁹

NATIONAL STANCES

United States of America

The US has declared that one of its top priorities as a security and financial issue is digital fraud and cybercrime. Domestically, the FBI, DOJ, and Treasury run takedown operations against scam networks, with documentation of domain seizures and foreign actor indictments. The FBI's

Internet Crime Complaint Center reported cybercrime losses of at least USD 16 billion in 2024,⁵⁰ showing both scale and urgency. Failures remain in bringing perpetrators physically to trial, as numerous operate from countries unamenable to cooperation, leaving sanctions and asset freezes as the primary tools. The US has several issues with complex money laundering chains and large fraud operations, resulting in continuing large losses and persistent enforcement challenges.

Iran

Iran has always been infamous for its deployment of wiper malware as well as its disruptive cyber campaigns. Regional tensions, specifically with Israel, has led Iran to carry out their cyber threat operations against its adversaries often. Iran has had a history of using cyberattacks against the United States.⁵¹ In 2010, a computer worm known as Stuxnet was said to have infiltrated the nuclear centrifuges controlling computers in Iran, causing physical damage and preventing operations. This was a joint endeavour between the USA and Israel. U.S. assets experienced an increase in cyberattacks originating from Iran.⁵² UNODC has been actively present in Iran since 1999. The UNODC Country Partnership Programme in Iran between 2023-2026 is now the new hallmark of UNODC's partnership with Iran, with the aim to counter activities related to money laundering, organised crime, and financing terrorism.⁵³

⁴⁸ *Fighting crime*. Document fraud. (n.d.). <https://www.frontex.europa.eu/what-we-do/fighting-crime/document-fraud/>

⁴⁹ *News*. False and Authentic Documents Online system (FADO). (n.d.). <https://www.frontex.europa.eu/media-centre/news/news-release/false-and-authentic-documents-online-system-fado--02Ky1q>

⁵⁰ FBI says cybercrime costs rose to at least \$16 billion in 2024 | reuters. (n.d.-d). <https://www.reuters.com/world/us/fbi-says-cybercrime-costs-rose-least-16-billion-2024-2025-04-23/>

⁵¹ *Analysis of the Iranian cyber attack landscape*. IronNet. (n.d.). <https://www.ironnet.com/blog/iranian-cyber-attack-updates>

⁵² (N.d.-k). https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/IF/HTML/IF11406.web.html

⁵³ Mohammad.sepehrnoush@Un.org. (n.d.). *United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime*. UNODC Iran Supports Equipping the Laboratory of the Iranian Financial Intelligence Unit. <https://www.unodc.org/islamicrepublicofiran/en/unodc-iran-supports-equipping-the-laboratory-of-the-iranian-financial-intelligence-unit.html>

Inspection of a smart training laboratory in the
Financial Intelligence Unit of Iran
Source: UNODC/Islamic Republic of Iran

Brazil

Brazil faces a surge in cyberattacks, which have become increasingly sophisticated. Child sexual



exploitation through the internet, phishing, bank fraud, as well as the subtraction of cryptoassets and ransomware has become a new trendsetter. New technological means of "ransomware" add forensic complexity. Criminal groups are developing operational-systems-based tools, customized to each victim, that leave little tracks and have a small presence on disks.

CASE STUDIES

Large-Scale Scam Compounds in South East Asia

Transnational organised crime in Southeast Asia is currently evolving at a rapid rate. This evolution has been marked by the proliferation of industrial-scale cyber-enabled fraud and scam centres, driven by sophisticated transnational syndicates and interconnected networks of money launderers, human traffickers, data brokers, and a growing number of other specialist service providers and facilitators. It follows years of mounting enforcement and regulatory efforts targeting cross-border cash movement and money laundering related to unregulated casinos

and online gambling operations. These are commonly used as fronts for criminal activities - with many physically relocating and converging around inaccessible and autonomous non-state armed group-controlled territories, Special Economic Zones (SEZs), and other vulnerable border areas across the region, especially in the Mekong, which have served as breeding grounds for criminal networks.

As a result, Asian crime syndicates have emerged as definitive market leaders in cyber-enabled fraud, money laundering, and underground banking globally, actively enhancing collaboration with other major criminal networks around the world.

The situation has been further compounded by the rise of new illicit online marketplaces native to Southeast Asia, which have dramatically expanded criminal revenue streams and enabled transnational organised crime to scale up operations. The emergence of these platforms has not only created new opportunities to expand physical bases of operation overseas, but is increasingly being used by criminal groups outside of Southeast Asia to launder proceeds of crime and circumvent formal financial systems.

Bankruptcy of FTX in The Bahamas

FTX, at one point one of the largest cryptocurrency exchanges in the world, filed for bankruptcy in 2022. The source of its collapse came from the funneling of money from customer funds into risky Alameda Research positions. The incident wasn't a classic external hacking case but a case of fund misappropriation and internal illegal financial flows. Sam Bankman-Fried, founder of FTX, was then convicted by U.S. prosecutors on counts of fraud and conspiracy.

After the public exposé of FTX's liquidity crisis, analysts observed large outflows from official FTX wallets. User funds were non-withdrawable

and were not allowed to be liquidated as they were tied up in risky bets. Nearly USD 370 million disappeared in the wake of the collapse, and user assets were eroded.⁵⁴ The issue with a deregulated system like cryptocurrency and tokens is the forensic complexities that are involved. Policymakers emphasize the need for new and updated regulations regarding virtual assets and stronger anti-money laundering controls. The major culpability in this crisis lies among the internal actors; however, the ability to commit this crime at that time scale without arrest reflects a severe lack of proper jurisdiction to curb cybercrime in digital asset markets.



Sam Bankman-Fried, CEO of FTX testifying in Congress

Source: Alex Wong via Getty Images

Romance Investment Scams in Australia

In 2024, Scamwatch received reports showing Australians lost USD 23.6 million to romance scams, with an average individual loss of USD 24,216. These scams majorly affected people aged 35 and above, mostly the ones who are widowed, divorced, or seeking relationships. Scammers often pose as potential romantic partners to trick individuals into investing in schemes they claim have made them wealthy. The advent of Deepfake technology is allowing

scammers to create highly realistic videos, impersonating made-up love interests and exploiting the images of real people in the process.

Between January 2024 and May 2025, men were more likely to report romance scams; however, women reported higher financial losses -USD 20.1 million compared to USD 13.3 million for men. On average, women lost more per scam - USD 36,091 compared to USD 17,089 for men. People aged 65 and over had the highest total losses at USD 11.7 million.⁵⁵ Two common methods were used. The first, romance baiting, typically involves grooming a romantic interest to take up fake investment opportunities, often involving cryptocurrency. The second, the 'long-term romance scam', sees the scammer cultivate an emotional connection over an extended period of time. These criminals construct elaborate stories to extract money or to coerce people into unknowingly becoming money mules.

CONCLUSION

The threat of transnational organized cybercrime is evolving faster now than at any previous point in history, driven by highly sophisticated syndicates and complex networks of money launderers, service-based business models, and technologies, including malware, generative AI, and deepfakes. It leads to financial losses of billions of dollars annually, undermines financial systems, and exploits vulnerable populations. Transnational action, by not tackling cybercrime at its source, provides only a reprieve. In order to create both an enabling environment for enterprises and to protect users from digital exploitation, it is necessary that countries have a clear legal framework and sufficient law

⁵⁴ U.S. probes how \$370 million vanished in Hack after FTX bankruptcy - bloomberg news | reuters. (n.d.-n).

<https://www.reuters.com/legal/us-probes-how-370-million-vanished-hack-after-ftx-bankruptcy-bloomberg-news-2022-12-27/>

⁵⁵ National Anti-Scam Centre. (2025, July 11). *New Fusion cell focuses on emotional and financial harm of romance scams*.

<https://www.nasc.gov.au/news/new-fusion-cell-focuses-on-emotional-and-financial-harm-of-romance-scams>

enforcement and technological capacities in place to fight such issues. Such frameworks and capacities are critical both to the protection of internet users within the country and to the provision of effective support to foreign law enforcement agencies requesting international cooperation to deal with cybercrime networks.